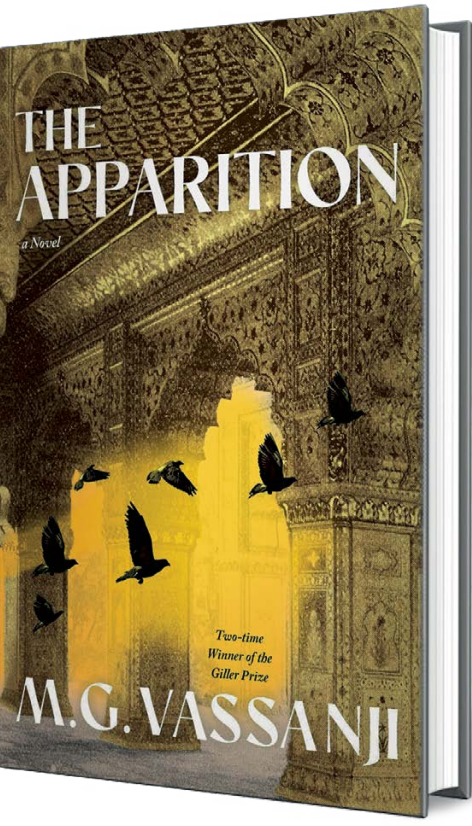


others a giant bird. Then, with startling abruptness, the spectral vision solidifies into an invasion of bird-headed entities.

Appearing from the skies, these Avians, as they are known, behead the Sultan and take over the throne. Aside from this brief spasm of violence, the newcomers establish an altogether calmer, kinder rule.

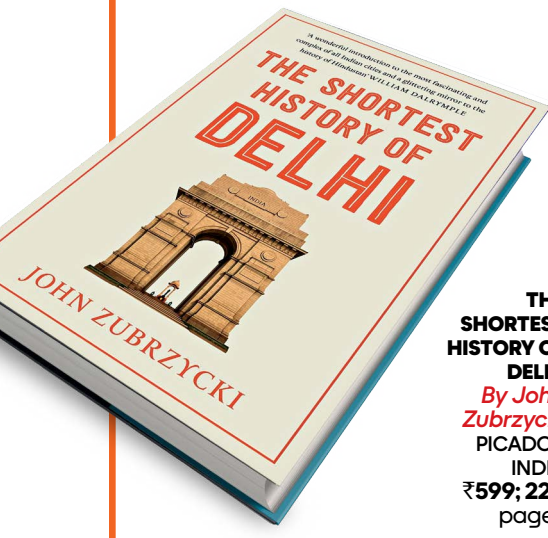
The historian is eventually won over and travels to the hidden, mountainous region of Birdland. He falls in love with a bird-woman, marries and has a child. Only gradually does he understand that he has become a prisoner of that other culture. When he discovers the dark secret by which the Avians maintain their cultural integrity, he can only be horrified, not escape.

Vassanji presents this complex saga with marvellous economy. The obvious analogy is the appearance of colonial powers all across the global South. But this is no "us and them" fable. Through Al-Shirazi, we recognise the peculiar pain of cultural assimilation, which can work in both directions. Styles of clothing, food and language are each a form of invasion. Many of us in today's world participate in them, as both invaders and invaded. In lyrical language and with deep understanding, the novelist pokes his literary fingers into a wound that arcs across the centuries and far into our shared futures. ■

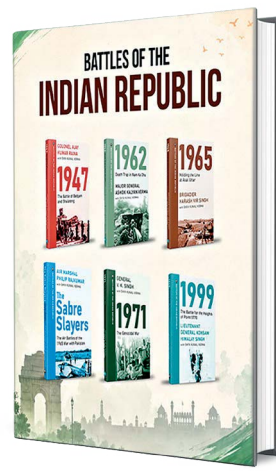
—Manjula Padmanabhan

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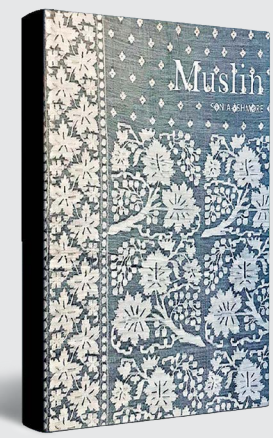
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—compiled by Amit Dixit